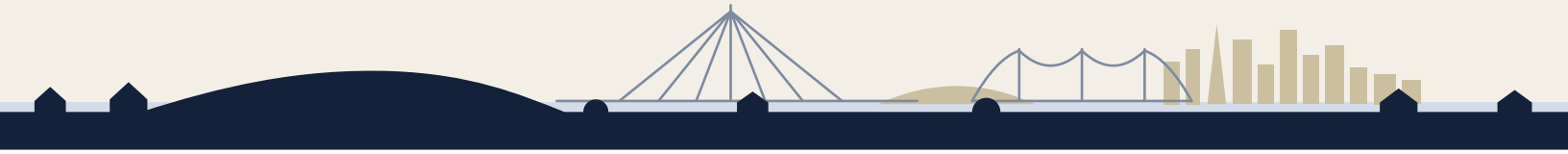
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What to know about buying a home in El Cerrito

From the flats to the hills, homes here move fast and sell over asking. Here is where the market stands and how to write the offer that gets picked.

$1.18M	115%	14 days	86%
MEDIAN SALE PRICE	SALE TO LIST	DAYS ON MARKET	SOLD OVER ASKING

All El Cerrito neighborhoods · detached single-family homes · last 12 months · 175 MLS sales



1 Do this first, before you shop

- ☑ **Get pre-approved.** Knowing your budget is the critical first step.
- ☑ **Set aside cash** for earnest money (about 3% of price) and a possible appraisal gap, so a release never catches you short.

2 How a listing moves

DAYS 1–3
Listing goes live, usually midweek.

TWO WEEKENDS
Back-to-back weekends of open houses.

AROUND DAY 14
Offers due, usually midweek after the second weekend.

About two weeks to tour, read disclosures, and build your offer. We start prepping yours on day one.

3 The list price is low by design (I know, it's annoying)

Homes list low on purpose to draw multiple offers. **86% sold over asking** last year, and not by a few thousand. The typical home sold **15% over list**, sometimes hundreds of thousands over. Asking price won't win. To recommend an offer price, we use **broader market comps**, specifically recent sales in the area, plus what the **disclosure packet** tells us about the home.

> **Bottom line:** the highest number still loses if it misses the seller's terms on closing date or contingencies. Strategy is part of the offer.

4 Before you write an offer

- ☑ **Read the disclosure and inspection package first.** I turn it into a clear read with red flags and likely repair costs, so a short inspection window is all you need.
- ☑ **Set your number from the CMA:** recent comparable sales, repairs needed, and the listing team's strategy.

HOW EVERY HOME GETS REVIEWED

Disclosures and comps both run through **AgentPrep**. You get the home's real condition, red flags, repair costs, and likely sale price. No 200-page packet to decode.

5 What a winning offer looks like

Buyers here are more protected than in Berkeley. You can usually keep your contingencies, just on shorter timelines.

Short inspection	Keep it, but short: 7 to 10 days is common here. Waiving is an option on the most competitive homes.
Appraisal, 14 days	Often kept. If it appraises low, you can renegotiate or cover the gap in cash.
Loan, 14 days	Often kept. Release once you are fully underwritten.
Close in 14–21 days	A clean, on-time close still makes your offer stronger.

6 El Cerrito taxes & point-of-sale items

City transfer tax
1.2%, split between buyer and seller. Contra Costa County's 0.11% is paid by the seller. Offering to cover more can make your offer stand out.

Chicago Title rate table →

Property tax APPROX
A 1% base plus local assessments and bonds. Prorated at closing. We confirm the exact figure before you offer.

Sewer lateral
The private sewer lateral needs an EBMUD compliance certificate at sale. We settle who pays up front.

Usually $6,500–$10,000

Questions on any of this?
Text or call. I'll walk you through it, no pressure.

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